GENERAL REMARKS BY DR. LAWRENCE BAYODE

Mr. Lawrence Bayode, Director, Information and Communications Technology, Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC)

At the #AI4Elections World Press Conference and Ecosystem Roundtable

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Protocols

Distinguished guests, representatives of Rise Networks, development partners, technology innovators, members of civil society, academia, gentlemen of the press, ladies and gentlemen.

Let me begin with a simple observation: **The future of elections will not be determined by technology alone, but by how responsibly we use technology to strengthen public trust.**

Artificial Intelligence is transforming nearly every sector of human endeavour, and electoral administration cannot be an exception. The question before us is no longer whether AI has a role to play in elections, but how we can harness its potential without compromising the integrity, transparency and credibility of the electoral process.

I commend Rise Networks and its partners for bringing together the electoral community, technology ecosystem, researchers, civil society and young innovators through the #AI4Elections initiative.

INEC's Journey with Artificial Intelligence

At INEC, we recognise that Artificial Intelligence presents significant opportunities to improve electoral administration.

The Commission has already taken deliberate steps towards responsible AI adoption, including the establishment of an **Artificial Intelligence Division within the ICT Department** and the development of an **AI Governance Framework** to guide the responsible application of AI in our operations.

We are also exploring practical applications of AI in areas such as voter information services, electoral data management, operational efficiency and the detection of misinformation.

One important area of innovation is in election result management, where we are deploying technology that uses intelligent document processing to digitise polling-unit result sheets and perform consistency checks between entered figures and scanned results before transmission. This is intended to improve accuracy, reduce human errors and strengthen transparency.

These initiatives demonstrate that, for INEC, AI is not merely a subject of discussion. **We are moving from conversation to practical application, while maintaining human oversight, accountability and appropriate safeguards.**

Innovation, Collaboration and Electoral Integrity

Distinguished ladies and gentlemen, the #AI4Elections Hackathon presents an opportunity to harness the creativity of young Nigerians in addressing real electoral challenges.

We welcome innovations that can improve voter education, expand accessibility for persons with disabilities, bridge language barriers, strengthen information integrity and make electoral information more accessible to citizens.

However, as we prepare for the 2027 General Election, we must recognise that electoral technology operates within a highly sensitive environment.

Innovation must never come at the expense of electoral security, operational stability or public confidence.

INEC therefore encourages responsible experimentation using publicly available or appropriately authorised data, without exposing critical election infrastructure or compromising the Commission's statutory responsibilities.

We believe that meaningful collaboration between electoral institutions, academia, technology companies, civil society and development partners can produce solutions that are not only innovative but also practical, secure and sustainable.

Conclusion

As we launch this initiative, I would like to challenge our young innovators with one important question:

Can we develop AI solutions that do not merely demonstrate technological sophistication, but genuinely solve the problems confronting our electoral process?

That should be our collective ambition.

Let us remember that the ultimate beneficiaries of electoral innovation must be the Nigerian voters, whose confidence and participation remain central to our democracy.

On behalf of the Independent National Electoral Commission, I congratulate Rise Networks and its partners on this initiative and wish all participants a productive and impactful engagement.

Technology should serve democracy. Democracy should never become subservient to technology.

Thank you, and God bless the Federal Republic of Nigeria.